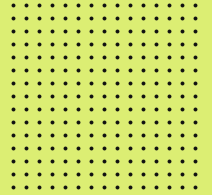


Lawhive · Hackathon 2026



CASE BRIEF / MESSY, MODERATE

CASE 08

THE BUILDER LEFT THE JOB HALF DONE AND NOW HE'S
THREATENING TO SUE ME

V. 01

LONDON 30/05/26

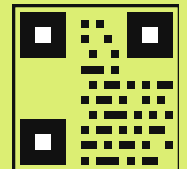
MESSY, MODERATE



CLAIMANT

Neil Whitlock

52, Leeds



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The builder left the job half done and now he's threatening to sue me

Neil Whitlock, 52, Leeds

PROBLEM, IN THE CLIENT'S OWN WORDS

I hired a local contractor to renovate my kitchen, the agreed price was £12,000. There's no proper contract, we agreed it over text and a conversation in my kitchen. He sent me a message saying '12k for the full job as discussed' and I replied 'sounds good, when can you start'.

He started well enough, they stripped out the old kitchen, did the rough plumbing and electrics, started fitting the new units. Then he just stopped turning up. For about a month he kept saying he'd be back 'next week' and never was.

Then he started saying there was extra work that I'd need to pay for, specifically moving a gas pipe and upgrading the electrical board which would be another £3,500 on top. I never agreed to any extras. He says I did verbally but I absolutely didn't.

After weeks of this I lost patience and withheld the last £4,000 of the £12,000. I'd already paid him £8,000 in two bank transfers. He went ballistic and sent me a text saying I was in breach and I'd be 'hearing from his solicitor'.

My family needed a functioning kitchen so I paid another contractor £800 to do the most urgent bits, they reconnected the sink and put in temporary worktops. I know this might have complicated things but we couldn't carry on without a kitchen.

I've since got a quote from a different contractor saying it'd cost £6,500 to finish everything to the original spec.

I'm also worried because the electrical work the first contractor did was never signed off by Building Control. Is that a problem?

KEY INFORMATION

Client	Neil Whitlock
Contractor	Steve Caldwell, Caldwell Renovations
Agreed price	£12,000 (no written contract)
Paid to date	£8,000 (two transfers)
Work start date	9 February 2026
First no show	Tuesday 24 February 2026
Remedial works paid	£800 (sink, temporary worktops)
Quote to complete	£6,500

DOCUMENTS PROVIDED

#	FILENAME	DESCRIPTION
01	text_messages_with_contractor.pdf	Full text history. Initial agreement ('12k for the full job as discussed' / 'sounds good, when can you start'), delays, the disputed extras conversation, and the final threatening message.
02	bank_transfer_1.pdf	Bank transfer confirmation for £4,000 (first instalment).
03	bank_transfer_2.pdf	Bank transfer confirmation for £4,000 (second instalment).
04	photos_incomplete_work.zip	12 photos of the kitchen in its half finished state. Partially fitted units, exposed plumbing, incomplete electrical work.
05	remedial_contractor_invoice.pdf	Invoice from the second contractor for £800 for emergency reconnection of the sink and temporary worktops.
06	completion_quote.pdf	Quote from a third contractor for £6,500 to complete the renovation to the originally agreed specification.
07	threatening_text.pdf	Screenshot of the final text from the original contractor: 'You owe me the money and you'll be hearing from my solicitor. You can't just stop paying when you feel like it.'